

Postpartum Recovery

& Wellness Guide for New Moms

By Daniel Tesfamariam

A Comprehensive Health & Wellness Workbook

Medical Disclaimer

MEDICAL DISCLAIMER: This workbook is for informational purposes only and does not constitute medical advice. Always consult your healthcare provider before making changes to your diet, exercise, or medication. The author is not a licensed medical professional. Never disregard professional medical advice or delay seeking it because of something you have read in this workbook.

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Introduction

The postpartum period (often called the 'fourth trimester') is a time of enormous physical, emotional, and social change. Your body has done something extraordinary, and it deserves intentional care as it heals. This guide supports you through recovery with practical tools and compassionate guidance.

Remember: Recovery is not linear, and you do not need to 'bounce back.' You are becoming someone new - a mother. Give yourself grace.

Chapter 1: Understanding Postpartum Recovery

Timeline of Physical Recovery

Week 1-2: Immediate Healing

- Uterus begins contracting back to size
- Lochia (postpartum bleeding) is heaviest
- Perineum or incision healing begins
- Breast milk comes in (days 2-5)
- Hormone crash (baby blues possible)

Weeks 2-6: Early Recovery

- Bleeding gradually decreases
- Energy slowly returns
- Breastfeeding establishing (or bottle feeding routine)
- Sleep deprivation peaks
- 6-week postpartum check-up

Months 2-6: Continued Healing

- Core and pelvic floor strengthening
- Hormones gradually stabilizing
- Hair changes (postpartum shedding around month 3-4)
- Gradual return to exercise

Months 6-12+: Full Recovery

- Full healing takes 12-18 months (not 6 weeks)
- Body composition changes may be permanent - and that's okay
- Mental health needs ongoing attention

Red Flags - Seek Immediate Medical Care

- Heavy bleeding (soaking a pad in 1 hour or large clots)
- Fever over 100.4F
- Severe headache or vision changes
- Thoughts of harming yourself or baby (call 988 or go to ER)
- Signs of infection (foul smell, increasing pain, redness)
- Chest pain or difficulty breathing
- Calf pain or swelling (possible blood clot)

Chapter 2: Your Recovery Assessment

Birth Information

Baby born: __/__/____ Method: []Vaginal []C-section

Complications: _____

Feeding method: []Breast []Bottle []Combo

Support system: _____

Weekly Check-In (complete each week)

Date: __/__/____ Weeks postpartum: ____

Physical pain level (1-10): ____

Energy level (1-10): ____

Mood (1-10): ____

Sleep (hours in 24hrs): ____

Feeding going well: []Yes []Struggling []Need help

Bonding with baby (1-10): ____

Anxiety level (1-10): ____

Support received (1-10): ____

Chapter 3: Physical Healing

Core & Pelvic Floor Recovery

Your core and pelvic floor need specific, gentle rehabilitation after pregnancy and birth. Do NOT jump back into crunches or high-impact exercise.

Week 1-2 Exercises (gentle)

- Diaphragmatic breathing: Inhale belly expands, exhale belly draws in gently
- Pelvic floor activation: Gentle Kegel (lift and hold 5 sec, release)
- Gentle walking as tolerated

Weeks 3-6 (building)

- Bridge pose (gentle)
- Bird dog (on all fours, extend opposite arm/leg)
- Clamshells (side-lying hip strengthening)
- Modified planks (on knees)
- Longer walks

After 6 Weeks (with clearance)

- Gradually increase intensity
- Continue pelvic floor work
- Consider pelvic floor physiotherapy if any leaking, pain, or heaviness

C-Section Recovery

- No lifting anything heavier than baby for 6 weeks
- Support incision when coughing/laughing
- Gentle scar massage after 6 weeks (prevents adhesions)
- Walk daily as soon as possible (prevents blood clots)
- Monitor incision for signs of infection

Chapter 4: Postpartum Mood & Mental Health

Understanding Postpartum Mental Health

Baby Blues (80% of new mothers)

- Occurs days 2-14 postpartum
- Crying, mood swings, overwhelm
- Resolves on its own within 2 weeks
- Caused by sudden hormone drop

Postpartum Depression (1 in 7 mothers)

- Persists beyond 2 weeks or worsens over time
- Persistent sadness, loss of interest
- Difficulty bonding with baby
- Changes in appetite and sleep (beyond baby-related)
- Feelings of worthlessness or guilt
- THIS IS TREATABLE - please reach out for help

Postpartum Anxiety

- Excessive worry about baby's health/safety
- Racing thoughts, inability to relax
- Physical symptoms: racing heart, nausea, tension
- Intrusive scary thoughts (common and treatable)

Mood Self-Screening (Edinburgh Postnatal Depression Scale)

Complete at 2, 6, and 12 weeks postpartum. Share results with your provider.

In the past 7 days:

1. I have been able to laugh and see the funny side of things: ____/3
 2. I have looked forward with enjoyment to things: ____/3
 3. I have blamed myself unnecessarily when things went wrong: ____/3
 4. I have been anxious or worried for no good reason: ____/3
 5. I have felt scared or panicky for no good reason: ____/3
 6. Things have been getting on top of me: ____/3
 7. I have been so unhappy that I have had difficulty sleeping: ____/3
 8. I have felt sad or miserable: ____/3
 9. I have been so unhappy that I have been crying: ____/3
 10. The thought of harming myself has occurred to me: ____/3
- Total: ____/30 (Score 10+ = discuss with provider immediately)

Chapter 5: Nutrition for Recovery & Breastfeeding

Postpartum Nutritional Needs

Your body needs MORE nutrition after birth, not less. Now is not the time for dieting. Focus on nourishing recovery and milk production (if breastfeeding).

Key Nutrients

- Iron: Replenish blood loss (red meat, lentils, spinach)
- Protein: Tissue repair, milk production (aim 75-100g/day)
- Calcium: Bone health (depleted during pregnancy/nursing)
- Omega-3 DHA: Brain health for you and baby
- Vitamin D: Often depleted, support immune health
- Choline: Brain development if breastfeeding
- Fluids: Extra 24-32oz if breastfeeding

Easy Postpartum Meals (one-handed, minimal prep)

- Overnight oats prepared the night before
- Protein smoothies (prep ingredients in freezer bags)
- Egg muffins (batch cook for the week)
- Rotisserie chicken with pre-washed salad
- Trail mix with nuts, seeds, dried fruit
- Pre-made bone broth (sip throughout day)
- Nut butter on toast with banana
- Batch soups and stews (freezer meals)

Chapter 6: New Mom Daily Tracker

Daily Postpartum Tracker - Page 1

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One thing I did well today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Baby feeds (count): _____
My meals eaten: _____
Water intake: _____
Sleep (total hours in 24hrs): _____
Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Baby mood/fussiness: _____
Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

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My meals eaten: _____
Water intake: _____
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Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Baby mood/fussiness: _____
Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

Daily Postpartum Tracker - Page 14

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Baby feeds (count): _____
My meals eaten: _____
Water intake: _____
Sleep (total hours in 24hrs): _____
Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
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My meals eaten: _____
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Mood (1-10): _____
Baby mood/fussiness: _____
Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Baby feeds (count): _____
My meals eaten: _____
Water intake: _____
Sleep (total hours in 24hrs): _____
Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Baby mood/fussiness: _____
Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

Daily Postpartum Tracker - Page 15

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Baby feeds (count): _____
My meals eaten: _____
Water intake: _____
Sleep (total hours in 24hrs): _____
Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Baby mood/fussiness: _____
Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Baby feeds (count): _____
My meals eaten: _____
Water intake: _____
Sleep (total hours in 24hrs): _____
Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Baby mood/fussiness: _____
Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

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My meals eaten: _____
Water intake: _____
Sleep (total hours in 24hrs): _____
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Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

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Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

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Baby feeds (count): _____
My meals eaten: _____
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Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Baby mood/fussiness: _____
Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

Daily Postpartum Tracker - Page 16

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Baby feeds (count): _____
My meals eaten: _____
Water intake: _____
Sleep (total hours in 24hrs): _____
Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
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My meals eaten: _____
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Sleep (total hours in 24hrs): _____

Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Baby mood/fussiness: _____
Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

Day: _____ Date: __/__/____
Baby feeds (count): _____
My meals eaten: _____
Water intake: _____
Sleep (total hours in 24hrs): _____
Pain level (1-10): _____
Mood (1-10): _____
Baby mood/fussiness: _____
Help received from: _____
Self-care done: _____
One thing I did well today: _____

Chapter 7: Progress & Milestone Tracking

Monthly Recovery Milestones

Month 1 Postpartum

Date: __/__/__

Physical recovery (1-10): ____

Emotional wellbeing (1-10): ____

Sleep pattern: ____

Feeding going: ____

Support level (1-10): ____

What I'm proud of: _____

What I need help with: _____

Month 2 Postpartum

Date: __/__/__

Physical recovery (1-10): ____

Emotional wellbeing (1-10): ____

Sleep pattern: ____

Feeding going: ____

Support level (1-10): ____

What I'm proud of: _____

What I need help with: _____

Month 3 Postpartum

Date: __/__/__

Physical recovery (1-10): ____

Emotional wellbeing (1-10): ____

Sleep pattern: ____

Feeding going: ____

Support level (1-10): ____

What I'm proud of: _____

What I need help with: _____

Month 4 Postpartum

Date: __/__/__

Physical recovery (1-10): ____

Emotional wellbeing (1-10): ____

Sleep pattern: ____

Feeding going: ____

Support level (1-10): ____

What I'm proud of: _____

What I need help with: _____

Month 5 Postpartum

Date: __/__/__

Physical recovery (1-10): ____

Emotional wellbeing (1-10): ____

Sleep pattern: _____

Feeding going: _____

Support level (1-10): ____

What I'm proud of: _____

What I need help with: _____

Month 6 Postpartum

Date: __/__/__

Physical recovery (1-10): ____

Emotional wellbeing (1-10): ____

Sleep pattern: _____

Feeding going: _____

Support level (1-10): ____

What I'm proud of: _____

What I need help with: _____

Week 1 Review

Date Range: __/__/__ to __/__/__

Physical healing progress:

Mood and emotional state:

Sleep (best I can get):

Nutrition (am I eating enough?):

Help I need to ask for:

Something that made me smile:

Self-care I managed:

One thing I want to do differently:

Week 2 Review

Date Range: __/__/__ to __/__/__

Physical healing progress:

Mood and emotional state:

Sleep (best I can get):

Nutrition (am I eating enough?):

Help I need to ask for:

Something that made me smile:

Self-care I managed:

One thing I want to do differently:

Week 3 Review

Date Range: __/__/__ to __/__/__

Physical healing progress:

Mood and emotional state:

Sleep (best I can get):

Nutrition (am I eating enough?):

Help I need to ask for:

Something that made me smile:

Self-care I managed:

One thing I want to do differently:

Week 4 Review

Date Range: __/__/____ to __/__/____

Physical healing progress:

Mood and emotional state:

Sleep (best I can get):

Nutrition (am I eating enough?):

Help I need to ask for:

Something that made me smile:

Self-care I managed:

One thing I want to do differently:

Frequently Asked Questions

Q: When will I feel like myself again?

The 'new normal' develops gradually over 6-12 months. You may not return to your pre-baby self - you're becoming a new version. Be patient and compassionate with this transformation.

Q: Is it normal to not feel bonded to my baby immediately?

Yes. Bonding is not always instant. It develops over time through care, skin-to-skin contact, and attentive presence. If bonding difficulties persist, talk to your provider.

Q: When can I exercise again?

Light walking can start days after vaginal birth (when comfortable). More structured exercise after 6-week clearance. C-section requires longer recovery. Always start gentle.

Q: How do I know if I have postpartum depression vs. baby blues?

Baby blues resolve within 2 weeks. PPD persists, worsens, or begins after 2 weeks. If symptoms interfere with functioning or bonding, or include thoughts of harm - seek help immediately.

Q: Is breastfeeding supposed to hurt?

Initial tenderness is common, but persistent pain is NOT normal and usually indicates latch issues. See a lactation consultant. Fed is best - however you choose to feed your baby.

Q: When will my body look normal again?

Your body grew a human. It may never look exactly the same, and that's okay. Focus on how you FEEL rather than how you look. Give yourself at least 12-18 months before evaluating.

Q: How do I accept help?

Practice saying 'yes' to every offer. Be specific: 'Could you bring a meal?' or 'Could you hold baby while I shower?' People want to help - let them. This is not weakness.

Q: Is it normal to feel overwhelmed?

Absolutely. New parenthood is one of life's biggest transitions. Overwhelm is expected. It's not normal to feel hopeless, to not eat/sleep at all, or to have thoughts of harm - those need professional support.

Quick-Reference: Daily New Mom Checklist

- ☐ Ate at least 3 meals (nourishing, not perfect)
- ☐ Drank plenty of water
- ☐ Slept when baby slept (at least once)
- ☐ Fresh air (even 5 min on porch counts)
- ☐ Connected with another adult
- ☐ One small thing just for me
- ☐ Accepted help or asked for it
- ☐ Said something kind to myself

Notes & Reflections

Use these pages to record your thoughts, observations, and insights as you work through this workbook.

Notes - Page 1

Date: ____/____/____

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and extend across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Notes - Page 2

Date: ____/____/____

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Notes - Page 3

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Notes - Page 4

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Notes - Page 5

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Notes - Page 11

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Notes - Page 12

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Notes - Page 15

Date: ____/____/____

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Notes - Page 16

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Notes - Page 19

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Notes - Page 20

Date: ____/____/____

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About the Author

Daniel Tesfamariam is a health and wellness content creator dedicated to making evidence-based health information accessible and actionable. Through carefully designed workbooks and guides, Daniel helps people take control of their health journey with practical tools, trackers, and strategies.

For more health and wellness resources, visit our Etsy shop for additional workbooks, planners, and guides covering nutrition, fitness, mental health, and chronic condition management.

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- Leave a review if this workbook helped you
- Share your progress - we love hearing success stories

Thank you for investing in your health. You deserve to feel your best.